A FORCE OF THE FUTURE

Keeping the Chinese at bay, streamlining and modernising the armed forces, fortifying defence infrastructure and building self-reliance...it has been a long and demanding to-do list

By PRADIP R. SAGAR



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Rajnath Singh
Minister of Defence

AN ARMY MARCHES ON its stomach, but its provisions roll along roads. In January 2023, a month after a clash along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) between Indian and Chinese troops in Tawang, Arunachal Pradesh, defence minister Rajnath Singh visited the northeastern state. Using the peppy shorthand for 'brother', he quipped that the BRO (Border Road Organisation) personnel were "brothers of our armed forces". Indeed, the Narendra Modi government has accorded the utmost importance to building border roads. In the past five years, the BRO has constructed over 3,600 km of roads, mostly along the LAC, at an overall cost of Rs 20,767 crore, to facilitate all-weather access to forward areas. With this massive infrastructure push, the Indian military has improved its battle readiness along the China border. Little wonder then that in the Union budget for 2023-24, BRO's capital outlay is Rs 5,000 crore, as against Rs 3,500 crore in 2022-23—a jump of 43 per cent.

In his Independence Day address in 2019, Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced that the country's military would have a Chief of Defence Staff—the highest-ranking military officer and chairman of the chief of staffs committee. In December that year, then army chief Gen. Bipin Rawat was named the first CDS. On the new CDS's agenda was the optimum utilisation of scarce resources through the integration of the military capabilities of the three services. However, his plan to create theatre commands for increased combat efficiency, was put on the backburner after his tragic death in December 2021.

From May 2020, a series of border clashes broke out between the Chinese and Indian armed forces along the LAC in Ladakh, as the former attempted incursions at various points